

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Family separation & reunification

EVACUATION SHELTER / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stay in a safe place, try the agreed contact and meeting plan, and record the missing person's last confirmed location and time. Keep children with a trusted caregiver. Use verified Red Cross or humanitarian family-tracing channels if available. Do not publish sensitive personal details or enter danger to search.

Do now.

**Record facts**

01

Write the last confirmed contact, location, time, description and medical needs. Distinguish what you know from rumours. Keep a recent photo privately if available.

**Try agreed channels**

02

Send a short text to the person and the out-of-area contact. Leave your own location and next check-in time. A sent message may not be delivered.

**Use the safe meeting plan**

03

Go to the meeting point only if the route and location are safe. Do not send several people independently into a hazardous area.

**Verify tracing services**

04

Use independently found Red Cross or humanitarian contacts. Check the organisation rather than trusting a forwarded number, and ask how information will be protected.

**Protect children**

05

Never hand a child to an unverified adult promising reunification. Keep a written contact card and involve a trusted caregiver or verified protection service.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If networks fail, follow the written reunion plan only where safe and leave a message with the agreed trusted contact. Keep your own location predictable rather than repeatedly moving between unsafe places.

Watch for.

Scammers may demand money or identity documents. Do not post full identity numbers, sensitive addresses or real-time movements publicly.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: record facts. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Scammers may demand money or identity documents. Do not post full identity numbers, sensitive addresses or real-time movements publicly.

Keep essentials within reach.

For family separation & reunification, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If networks fail, follow the written reunion plan only where safe and leave a message with the agreed trusted contact. Keep your own location predictable rather than repeatedly moving between unsafe places. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Keep one person coordinating the information so sightings, contacts and dates are not lost. Update the record when someone is found and tell verified tracing services to stop circulating old requests.

First decision: Record facts

Write the last confirmed contact, location, time, description and medical needs. Distinguish what you know from rumours. Keep a recent photo privately if available. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If networks fail, follow the written reunion plan only where safe and leave a message with the agreed trusted contact. Keep your own location predictable rather than repeatedly moving between unsafe places. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Scammers may demand money or identity documents. Do not post full identity numbers, sensitive addresses or real-time movements publicly. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Stay in a safe place, try the agreed contact and meeting plan, and record the missing person's last confirmed location and time. Keep children with a trusted caregiver. Use verified Red Cross or humanitarian family-tracing channels if available. Do not publish sensitive personal details or enter danger to search. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For family separation & reunification, keep the specific hazard in view: Scammers may demand money or identity documents. Do not post full identity numbers, sensitive addresses or real-time movements publicly.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Protect children. Never hand a child to an unverified adult promising reunification. Keep a written contact card and involve a trusted caregiver or verified protection service. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[ICRC · Reconnecting families](#)

<https://www.icrc.org/en/what-we-do/reconnecting-families>

[ICRC · Family Links](#)

<https://familylinks.icrc.org/>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/family-reunification/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.